# The Lao Initiative For Eating Healthy: Sodium Intake and Hypertension in the Lao Community

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## Abstract

Hypertension, a cardiovascular disease, is a global public health issue. Vulnerable populations are generally unaware of current health behavior risks that could lead to hypertension. This research focuses particularly on the ethnic Lao population in the Twin Cities, Minnesota metropolitan area. In this study, the Lao Assistance Center, has initiated a project to: 1) raise awareness about hypertension and the role of sodium intake in the Lao diets, 2) teach family cooks to recognize sodium levels in foods and modify recipes to reduce the amount of sodium and 3) encourage Lao restaurant owners to consider offering lower sodium dishes to their customers. Focus group interviews with restaurant owners and course assessment with family cooks resulted in increased awareness of the link between sodium intake and hypertension. Further, there is initial evidence of behavior change in: 1) diet and physical activity for family cooks and 2) modified menu options for restaurant customers.

## Introduction

- Hypertension is a global public health issue that accounts for approximately seventeen million deaths a year (World Health Organization, 2013).
- Southeast Asian refugees in America represent a population impacted by this health problem Following the Communist takeover of Vietnam, Laos, and Cambodia in 1975, nearly three million refugees left their homelands; with an estimated two million of them resettled in third countries- mostly in Western democracies (Um, 2013).
- Since relocating to America after the Vietnam War, there have been changes in lifestyle and diet. Laotian families have increasingly consumed greater amounts of meat, processed food, and fast food.
- Contributing to the problem of hypertension is the general lack of knowledge about the causes, signs and symptoms related to high blood pressure.
- Culturally-appropriate outreach efforts are critical to address this problem, especially when working with underserved populations.

## Community-based Participatory Action Research

### Process

- Active involvement of community members, organizational representatives, and researchers (Israel et al., 1998)
- Social, cultural, and community dynamics are integrated
- Knowledge gained from all subjects are utilized
- Promotes social equality and puts emphasis on collaborative partnerships (Israel et al., 1998)

## Methodology

### Models

- Community-based participatory action research approach (Israel et al., 1998)
- The transtheoretical model of health behavior change (Prochaska & Velicer, 1997)

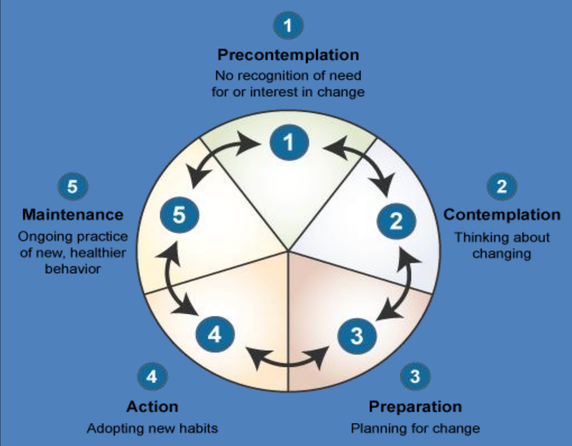
### Participants

- Collaborators include the Lao Center of Minnesota, University of Minnesota Extension educators and researchers, homemakers, as well as Lao and Thai restaurant owners and/or chefs

### Procedures

- Target population: Lao community in MN
- Observe series of 3 nutrition classes for family cooks; participants receive $100 upon completion
- Conduct 2 focus groups with restaurant owners; participants receive $200 voucher for fruits and vegetables grown locally (in collaboration with the Hmong American Farmers Association)
- Develop a model that can be replicated within the Lao community and potentially in other SE Asian communities

## Transtheoretical Model of Health Behavior Change



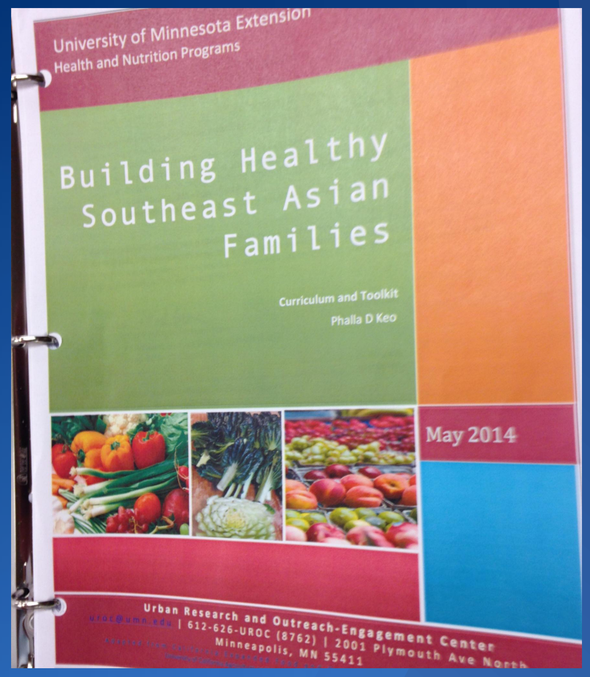

Source: http://www.esourceresearch.org/Portals/0/Uploads/Images/Glanz/Transtheoretical.png




## Results

- Project is currently in progress: research reflects preliminary results for activities completed to date
- 11 Lao family cooks who completed one nutrition class reported behavior changes:
  - Read food labels before purchasing
  - Increased physical activity
  - Experimented with modified recipes (more spice/less sodium)
  - Increased consumption of vegetables
  - Shared information with their families, specifically their children
- 2 focus groups planned for August 4 and 5 with 5-8 restaurant owners and/or chefs (per session)






## Observations

- Organic nature; researcher needed to be:
  - Flexible with participants and the community
  - Respectful of the culture and knowledge
  - Willing to switch roles as the searcher/observer, and participate in activities
- Participants were interactive and engaged
- Food is deeply rooted in the Lao culture

## References

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